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CO-OPERATE OR CONTROL? CREDIT UNION WEALTH MANAGEMENT IN CANADA

Marc-André Pigeon, Martine Vézina, and Jennifer Budney wrote this case solely to provide material for class discussion. The authors do not intend to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a managerial situation. The authors may have disguised certain names and other identifying information to protect confidentiality.

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Garth Manness, chief executive officer of Credit Union Central of Manitoba, sat down at his desk in November 2016 to read through a draft copy of *Credit Union Wealth Management Strategic Option Assessment*, a report that he had commissioned several months earlier from the global financial services consulting firm KPMG International Limited (KPMG).[1] As he was reading, Manness realized that the report might be the Canadian credit union sector's best—and possibly last—chance to fix a long-standing problem. Credit unions were democratically-controlled, member-owned financial co-operatives, sometimes referred to as "people's banks." Recently, credit unions were struggling to advance into the wealth management industry and compete effectively against the so-called "Big Five" banks. Since the early 1990s, these banks had dominated the wealth management sector (see Exhibit 1).

The KPMG report set out three strategic options that looked promising, but Manness knew that nothing was simple in the credit union industry. His organization represented almost three dozen member-owned credit unions in the Canadian province of Manitoba. His experience had taught him that disagreements were common in the industry, with opposing groups such as big versus small, rural versus urban, French versus English, and liberal versus conservative credit unions. Manness explained his role in the disputes:

> It's our job to figure out ways to meet credit unions' needs, period. They'll make decisions in the best interests of their members; some of them will be collective, some of them won't be. [Credit unions can be] frustrating to people who want to see collective decision-making at all fronts, but the bottom line is if we don't find a way to help them meet their member needs, they are not going to take a direction that is based on collective action.

Manness was the head of Project Gemini, the Canadian co-operative group set up to help credit unions better meet their members' wealth management needs. He knew that long-standing divisions within Manitoba were amplified by differences within all Canadian provinces. Many of those issues were rooted in decisions that had been made decades earlier. Manness also knew that credit unions were too small to make much headway in Canada's giant wealth management industry on their own. Some of the larger credit unions were pushing hard for a quick solution to their problems. However, Manness realized that the best strategic option was to secure the *most* buy-in from Canada's over 250 credit unions. Canadian credit unions had to work together, which had been proven many times before. This meant that decisions could not be made by a single individual, and that action could not proceed without collective agreement.

[1] KPMG Canada, *Credit Union Wealth Management Strategic Option Assessment* (Toronto, ON: KPMG International Limited, 2016).

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CO-OPERATIVE FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS IN CANADA

Credit Unions

Credit unions, and the Desjardins Group' caisses populaires, were co-operatives owned and controlled by their member-owners on a democratic "one-member, one-vote" basis. They provided the same financial services as banks, but with a different motive: to "serve people, and not profit" and to contribute to the well-being of their local communities.[2] As co-operatives, credit unions were governed by boards of directors comprising people elected from the membership. As businesses, credit unions operated with an understanding that they needed to meet the evolving needs of their members and reward them for using their products and services through patronage rebates—essentially profit distributions based on usage of the credit union (traditionally, profit was referred to as "member surplus" in co-operatives).

Historically, credit unions were located in areas where privately owned banks were reluctant to make an investment, or they served a niche demographic group (e.g., firefighters, Ukrainian communities). At their peak in the 1960s, there were more than 3,200 credit unions. Each one was a small business deeply embedded in a geographic and cultural community that served broader social objectives, in addition to providing financial services to its members.[3] Because of their attachment and responsiveness to their members and community, credit unions had a strong impulse for autonomy from governments (or other entity—even other credit unions). They rejected imposition against the interests of their members or their responsiveness to their community. This focus on local markets and relationship-based banking also reflected the fact that credit unions were generally regulated by the province, unlike major banks that were federally regulated.[4]

Credit unions were well aware that they were too small to compete on their own against the big banks. To be effective, they had to pool their efforts and avoid duplication, which embodied the principle of co-operation among credit unions. Starting in the 1940s, credit unions set up entities that eventually became known as "centrals." These entities acted as trade associations and provided shared services such as consulting, treasury, payments, lending, research, compliance, risk and governance, and operational guidance. Credit unions also used centrals to pool resources and invest in other companies, such as the wealth management companies Credential Financial Inc. (Credential) and Northwest & Ethical Investments L.P. (NEI) and the insurance companies Co-operators General Insurance Company (Co-operators) and CUMIS General Insurance Company (CUMIS).

By 2016, the credit union landscape outside Quebec had changed dramatically compared to the 1960s. These credit unions had evolved from being numerous small entities, unified in their co-operative identity and dwarfed by larger centrals, to becoming fewer, more fragmented entities that were less committed to cooperation. Over the years, a few credit unions had done most of the growing—either organically or through mergers, leading to a bifurcated system of several giant credit unions—some of which now were much bigger than the centrals; and therefore, less reliant on them. However, the many remaining smaller credit unions still needed the centrals for core services.

The centrals, in turn, were pursuing, or attempting to pursue, their own mergers to match this changing reality. In the late 1990s, for example, the Credit Union Central Canada led an effort to merge all nine

[2] Marc-André Pigeon, "Undoing a Co-operative Bargain: The Origins and Dissolution of Federal Accommodation of Provincial Credit Unions," Canadian Public Administration 66, no. 3 (2023): 303–18, https://doi.org/10.1111/capa.12534.
[3] Pigeon, "Undoing a Co-Operative Bargain."
[4] By the time wealth management negotiations were under way, in 2016, only one medium-sized credit union from New Brunswick had obtained a federal charter, which was made possible by changes in 2012 to federal regulations; Art Chamberlain, "Canadian Credit Union Expansion," *CU Management*, November 28, 2019, https://www.cumanagement.com/articles/2019/11/canadian-credit-union-expansion.

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provincial centrals from across the country into a single national entity, comparable to Desjardins Group (Desjardins), as discussed below. The original objective failed to materialize—some mergers of centrals were successful, but others failed. The centrals for Ontario and British Columbia merged into a new entity called Central 1 Credit Union in 2008, and centrals serving Canada's four Atlantic provinces merged into a single entity called Atlantic Central in 2012. However, a proposed merger of the three prairie centrals did not succeed and a subsequent effort to build a unified payments entity called PayCo also failed. This mixed record left scars of mistrust and doubt about the ability of the system to work together.[5]

Desjardins

Credit unions shared the same co-operative essence as Desjardins; that was their only similarity. Compared with the credit union system, Desjardins was older, bigger, almost exclusively French-speaking, based mostly in Quebec, and far more centralized. All of these aspects could be traced back to its origins. In 1900, Alphonse Desjardins opened the first caisse populaire in Levis, Quebec. That was the first example of a credit union or banking co-operative in North America. Over the ensuing years, and with the support of the then-powerful Catholic church, Desjardins members built a network of hundreds of caisses populaires. Collectively, Desjardins became the sixth-largest financial institution in Canada by 2016. With more than CA$275 billion[6] in assets, Desjardins dwarfed the nation's next biggest credit union, British Columbia's Vancouver City Savings Credit Union (Vancity) with $21.7 billion in assets in 2017.[7]

With the active support of policy makers, Desjardins became far more centralized than credit unions outside the province of Quebec. Over a 20-year period stretching from the 1990s and 2000s, Desjardins undertook a major re-engineering of its business processes to make them more sales oriented, albeit with the interests of its members in mind. This effort required a major cultural shift away from passively waiting for members to ask for services, to a new approach in which Desjardins employees pro-actively suggested products and services that could better serve the interests of members. Desjardins also unified its 11 regional entities and support activities, including insurance and wealth management services, under one group that actively supported the consolidation of all of the group's caisses populaires. William (Bill) Packham, the chief executive officer of Desjardins's brokerage firm Credential Qtrade Securities Inc. (Qtrade), highlighted the difference between Desjardins and credit unions:

> The history of Desjardins is that they had a lot of experience bringing their system into a more centralized control structure. They've gone through this process—credit unions are light-years behind them in that sense, right? There's not a lot of explicit coordination like there is in Desjardins.

Desjardins had a firm hold on the Quebec financial services market (approximately 40 per cent of banking and 25 per cent of wealth management), but the company wanted a stronger national voice for the co-operative finance sector and in federal public policy. However, its lobbying and financial interests were not well served by a disorganized credit union system that could be picked apart by competitors. Ultimately, Desjardins could be weakened in the fiercely competitive wealth management business, as Manness noted:

> [Based on] multiple conversations that we've had with Guy Cormier [the chief executive officer of Desjardins] and the senior team there . . . I think they believe strongly in a national co-operative movement and how that can best be created. I think they've come to the view that the best way this gets created is doing these types of things where we come together in the provision of services.

[5] Pigeon, "Undoing a Co-Operative Bargain."
[6] All currency amounts are in Canadian dollars unless otherwise specified.
[7] News and Events, "Vancity Posts Strong Financial Results for 2017," Vancity, February 28, 2018, https://www.vancity.com/AboutVancity/News/MediaReleases/YearEndFinancials_Feb28_2018.

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Manness's counterpart at Desjardins, Normand Paquin, echoed his view:

> I told them that we want a strong Canadian co-operative system. For us, that's important, especially when we lobby the federal government. I gave them the example that when there is legislation that affects us, we are much more effective if we are part of a large network of financial co-operatives than if Desjardins goes to the table by itself.

STRATEGIC OPTIONS

Most credit unions—especially the larger ones—recognized that the status quo in their wealth management services was increasingly unpalatable. They needed more wealth management revenue. In an era of low interest rates, profits margins from routine lending operations were shrinking while costs were rising. New expenses included upgrading digital banking platforms, addressing growing regulatory demands to hold more capital, and meeting emerging competitive threats. Karen Hoffmann, a senior vice-president at Vancity, Canada's largest credit union, commented on the industry's difficulties:

> The context of the marketplace and the financial industry is that margin income, which comes from your lending and your deposit activity, is being squeezed. So, credit unions are looking for other forms of revenue. And wealth management was another area where our revenue could be achieved. So, that was clearly a priority, especially for those credit unions that were seeing the squeeze more quickly than others.

However, to maximize wealth management revenue, credit unions needed to scale up, as noted by Kim Thompson, a senior vice-president at the wealth management firm Credential:

> Whenever we were doing our own sort of three-year projections and we were doing our future state of the organization, we needed more scale, we needed more sophistication for lack of a better word in the various different levers that we could pull on and we needed manufacturing.

To complicate matters, credit unions were feeling pressure to improve offerings for their aging members, who expected *their* credit unions to provide the same wealth management services as banks. But unlike banks, credit unions were expected to consider the best interests of the members, rather than merely padding the bottom line. If credit unions failed to meet the expectations of the members, they could lose *all* business (e.g., loans, credit cards, equity built up in the co-operative) to the major banks.

However, credit unions already had some advantages to work from. They had access to three types of business that offered competitive wealth management services (see Exhibit 2). If merged, these businesses could generate synergistic savings estimated at $20 million, according to the KPMG report that Manness was reviewing.

Credential

The brokerage firm Credential was co-owned by credit unions, through their central entities, and the insurance company Co-operators. However, the stake in Credential that Co-operators owned was held within its subsidiary CUMIS, which was also jointly owned by some credit unions, through their central. Co-operators itself was owned by 44 members, including retail grocery co-operatives, credit unions (through their centrals), and co-operative farm organizations. Credential was set up to provide wealth management products for credit unions, but it also provided products and services to competing independent fund managers and advisors. Despite having an indirect ownership stake in Credential, credit unions only

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purchased about 15 per cent of their wealth management products from the company. They sourced most of their investment products from larger, better-known, and high-profile investment fund operators. Over time, credit unions started questioning Credential's performance and brand image, claiming that it was not living up to the expectations of their investment advisors; and ultimately, of their members.

Qtrade

The brokerage firm Qtrade was started by former Credential managers. It offered products and services similar to those of Credential, but with an award-winning digital platform. Desjardins later acquired 100 per cent of Qtrade, even though its operations were exclusively outside Quebec. Desjardins already had the brokerage firm Disnat to serve its Quebec market. A 2016 ranking report gave Qtrade an A grade for the best online experience in the Canadian online discount brokerage landscape.[8]

NEI

NEI was an equal partnership between credit unions and Desjardins. The firm "manufactured" mutual funds. In the 1990s, NEI had pioneered ethical funds and shared profits back to the partners in the form of dividends, which reflected how much of NEI's funds they were able to sell. Similar to Credential, however, credit unions made little use of NEI's mutual fund offerings, which limited profit sharing opportunities and return on investment for both partners. As a result, Desjardins began to question the wisdom of its NEI partnership with credit unions. What had seemed like a natural and exclusive market for NEI products, had failed to fully materialize.

With their long history, credit unions were weighed down by fragmented and confusing ownership structures (see Exhibit 2). They also had little trust in Desjardins, which reciprocated with its own mistrust of credit unions. Other issues included difficulties in coordinating with Co-operators, concerns that centrals were holding back funds from flowing down to credit unions and their members, and a growing need to invest in the digital improvement of Credential and NEI. The fragmented ownership structures were especially problematic. For example, 209 of the 250 credit unions had some of their wealth management business with Qtrade, despite their collective membership owning part of its competitor Credential. As Vancity's senior vice-president Hoffmann stressed, the situation for credit unions "wasn't simple like it was at Desjardins."

The complex ownership structure also reflected the ambiguous data. It was difficult to determine the exact market share that credit unions had in wealth management businesses. Consultant and industry reports suggest that they held total wealth management assets of about $49.4 billion, representing about 3.6 per cent of the total industry.[9] This amount was well below the collective credit unions' 8 per cent national share in mortgage loans, 10 per cent share in small business lending, and 11 per cent share in the agricultural sector. Credit unions were also missing out on the "manufacturing" revenue that their bank competitors generated from the sale of in-house mutual funds to bank customers. NEI funds made up only 2 per cent of all mutual funds owned by credit union members, who mostly owned funds manufactured by other companies (e.g., Fidelity), including the banks.[10]

[8] Rob Carrick, "Online Broker Survey: Seeking the 'Wow' Factor," *The Globe and Mail*, December 11, 2016, https://www.theglobeandmail.com/globe-investor/investor-education/annual-online-brokerage-ranking-carrick/article33238778.
[9] Author calculation based on figures from a proprietary report privately commissioned by the subject company and "IFIC Releases Monthly Statistics for September 2016," *Sources Directory*, October 20, 2016, https://sources.com/Releases/NR2781.htm.
[10] KPMG Canada, *Credit Union Wealth Management Strategic Option Assessment*, 10.

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Credit unions seemed reluctant to interfere and promote NEI funds to their members, despite the high quality and potential of these funds to generate significant income for credit unions—and for their partner, Desjardins. In terms of online customer service experience, a 2016 Surviscor survey ranked Credential Direct eighth and Desjardins Online ninth, but Qtrade first among Canadian online brokers and.[11]

The stakes were high for the future of credit unions in Canada. The KPMG report that Manness was reviewing provided an opportunity to break the impasse over ownership and control, which had stalled an earlier effort to negotiate a merger among the three entities. To prepare the report, KPMG had interviewed key leaders and analyzed the financial modelling from the previous failed merger. It ruled out some options (e.g., selling NEI, buying Desjardins's stake in NEI) that would not address the fragmentation problem, create cumbersome decision-making, or break away from Desjardins. Finally, KPMG presented three viable options to the credit unions that Manness interpreted as follows:

> You can continue to negotiate to get 51 per cent control, but you had better be prepared to ultimately pay the price. You can . . . operate with the (existing) ownership positions which are there, which would actually put Desjardins in control, or you can look at some form of joint-venture partnership. Whatever you choose, we think going back to Desjardins is the best solution.

The three strategic options recommended by KPMG were structured around the idea of merging Credential, QTrade, and NEI into one wealth management entity, which was adapted from earlier negotiations. The three options were to merge with control, merge without control, or merge with a partnership:

- *Merge with control*—Credit unions could negotiate with Desjardins and Co-operators for a 51 per cent stake in a new merged entity. The original valuation by the credit unions estimated a cost of $77–$110 million for a control position, although Desjardins's analysis suggested that the true cost would be closer to $125–$160 million.
- *Merge without control*—Credit unions, Co-operators, and Desjardins could sell or "vend in" their ownership positions into a new merged entity, with ownership allocated on a pro-rated basis. None of the three organizations would have a clear control position, but they would not be required to pay for control (in theory, at least).
- *Merge with partnership*—Credit unions and Co-operators could form an equal-share joint venture with Desjardins. In the original valuation, credit unions estimated that Desjardins would owe as much as $28 million for a partnership position, although Desjardins's valuation suggested that it was the credit unions who would owe $8–$10 million.

As Manness considered the challenge of making a decision, he was reminded that a fourth choice was technically available—to choose none of the three options and do nothing. In fact, after negotiations for the control option had broken down back in 2015, the inevitable outcome was, in fact, to do nothing. That previous negotiation had been led by Manness's predecessor but could not reach a consensus on valuations, exposing sharp divisions between the credit unions and Desjardins, as well as among the various credit unions themselves. Another issue was the paradox of a crowded negotiation table—consisting of centrals, Co-operators, and Desjardins—that failed to include the credit unions. Ultimately, the credit unions would be responsible for selling the wealth management products, but they were mostly left out of the conversation. That oversight had led to frustration and complaints from the credit unions, who were still reeling from failed efforts to bring centrals together.

[11] "Canadian Online Brokerage Rankings," Surviscor, accessed April 11, 2017, https://www.surviscor.com/diy-investing/online-brokerage-review.

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Judging from the interviews KPMG had conducted, Manness could tell that Desjardins, and also the larger credit unions, were becoming impatient. Desjardins had invested a considerable amount of time and energy in negotiations with what seemed like a disorganized and fragmented credit union system, but it had a clear plan B strategy. Desjardins could choose to consolidate Qtrade into its Disnat online broker business in Quebec, which also had clients outside the province. Desjardins was well aware that working with the credit union system would be a challenge, sometimes described as working with "frogs in a wheelbarrow" because they seemed to enjoy the ride but eventually just wanted out. Daniel Sinclair, the Co-operators corporate development leader, articulated the challenge of coordinating the unique and separate leadership teams and strategies of credit unions:

> Some talk about the "credit union system" and it's not a system, it's 250 separate credit unions . . . and one member one vote, so it's not always as straightforward as, "Well BMO wants to buy ABC investment dealer, make an offer, and get 66 and two-thirds and then close out." That is not the process in the co-operative financial sector so . . . you do have to work very collaboratively and with intent.

Manness had reason to hope that he could keep everyone together, or "in the wheelbarrow." The credit unions and Co-operators, as the majority owners of CUMIS, had agreed to negotiate with Desjardins jointly, rather than separately, by means of a new legal entity called Holdco. This simplified the negotiating process. Manness also insisted on including the largest credit unions in the conversation to set up a formalized consultation process. There would be no surprises this time. In addition, his strong personal relationship with Paquin, his counterpart at Desjardins, would help build a foundation of trust to look beyond suspicions on both sides of the table, as he explained:

> I heard about devious motives, and I've never been a person to spend a lot of time trying to figure out the motives of other people. I had a pastor one day who said, "Garth, don't waste any time figuring out somebody else's motives. If you do a really good job in life you might figure out your own." That was valuable for me, because I can't predict what other people think or want to do. My view in life is that you take people at their word until they prove to you that they shouldn't be taken at their word and then you have to deal with that. It ended up, as these discussions moved forward, it ended up that Normand and I were leading the conversations on both sides and I found that we were always honest about where we were in the situation.

From a negotiating perspective, the table was set: there was unity, inclusion, purpose, and trust. Still, it was an open question as to which of the three strategic options set out by KPMG would generate enough credit union support to move forward, especially since the choice to do nothing and keep the status quo (which had ended earlier negotiations) was still viable. Somehow, credit unions would have to make a choice.

As Manness got up from his desk to begin the process of discussing the options with the credit unions, he realized that he would soon find out whether the sixth international co-operative principle—co-operation among co-operatives—was more than just idle words to the credit unions.

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EXHIBIT 1: CANADIAN BIG FIVE BANKS: MARKET SHARES IN WEALTH MANAGEMENT AND ONLINE PLATFORMS

Wealth management was the term used to describe the provision of financial planning and the sale of investment products to a wide range of clients, from "merely" affluent (with $500,000 or more in savings to invest) to ultra-high-net-worth clients. As a discipline, it incorporated financial planning, portfolio management, and other financial services, such as taxation, retirement planning, and estate management. Wealth management services were offered by a range of organizations, including investment banks, asset managers, custodial banks, retail banks, and financial planners.

The Canadian wealth management industry was growing rapidly. It was estimated, for example, that between 2015 and 2024, as baby boomers retired and their wealth was being transferred down to younger generations, assets worth around $885 billion would be passed down with over 70 per cent in financial assets, generating a surge in demand for retail investment funds.

In Canada, the market was controlled by a small number of large firms and was often described as oligopolistic. The major players in this industry were private banks, commonly known as the "Big Five" (see below). Each of these banks had their own investment platform and fund suppliers. Other large players in the investment industry with significant assets under management included Raymond James Financial Inc., BlackRock Inc., Fidelity Investments Canada ULC, CI Global Asset Management, and Mackenzie Investments.

The wealth management industry evolved significantly over the years, moving from a product-centric approach to one more focused on advice. With this evolution in approach also come a change in the products sold (e.g., exchange-traded funds, passive mutual fund management) and the channels used by clients (e.g., digital platforms). As negotiations among credit unions were taking place, the wealth management sector was facing the threat of disruption from new entrants such as WealthSimple Inc. (founded in 2014) that promised user-friendly online interfaces paired with low-cost buying and selling of bonds, stocks, mutual funds, and other financial products. New entrants in the wealth management market also promised simplified securities management with personalized portfolios of low-cost indexed funds.

Bank	2015 Global Operating Income (in CA$ Million)	2015 Global Operating Profit (in CA$ Million)	Online Investment Platform	Investment Fund Supplier
Royal Bank of Canada (RBC)	13,379	6,579	RBC Direct Investing	RBC Global Asset Management
Toronto Dominion Bank (TD)	12,316	5,402.9	TD Direct Investing	TD Asset Management
Bank of Nova Scotia (Scotiabank)	8,095	3,031.5	Scotia iTrade	Scotia Global Asset Management
Bank of Montreal (BMO)	6,639	2,801	BMO InvestorLine	BMO Investments
Canadian Imperial Bank of Commerce (CIBC)	8,499	3,427	CIBC Investors Edge	CIBC Asset Management

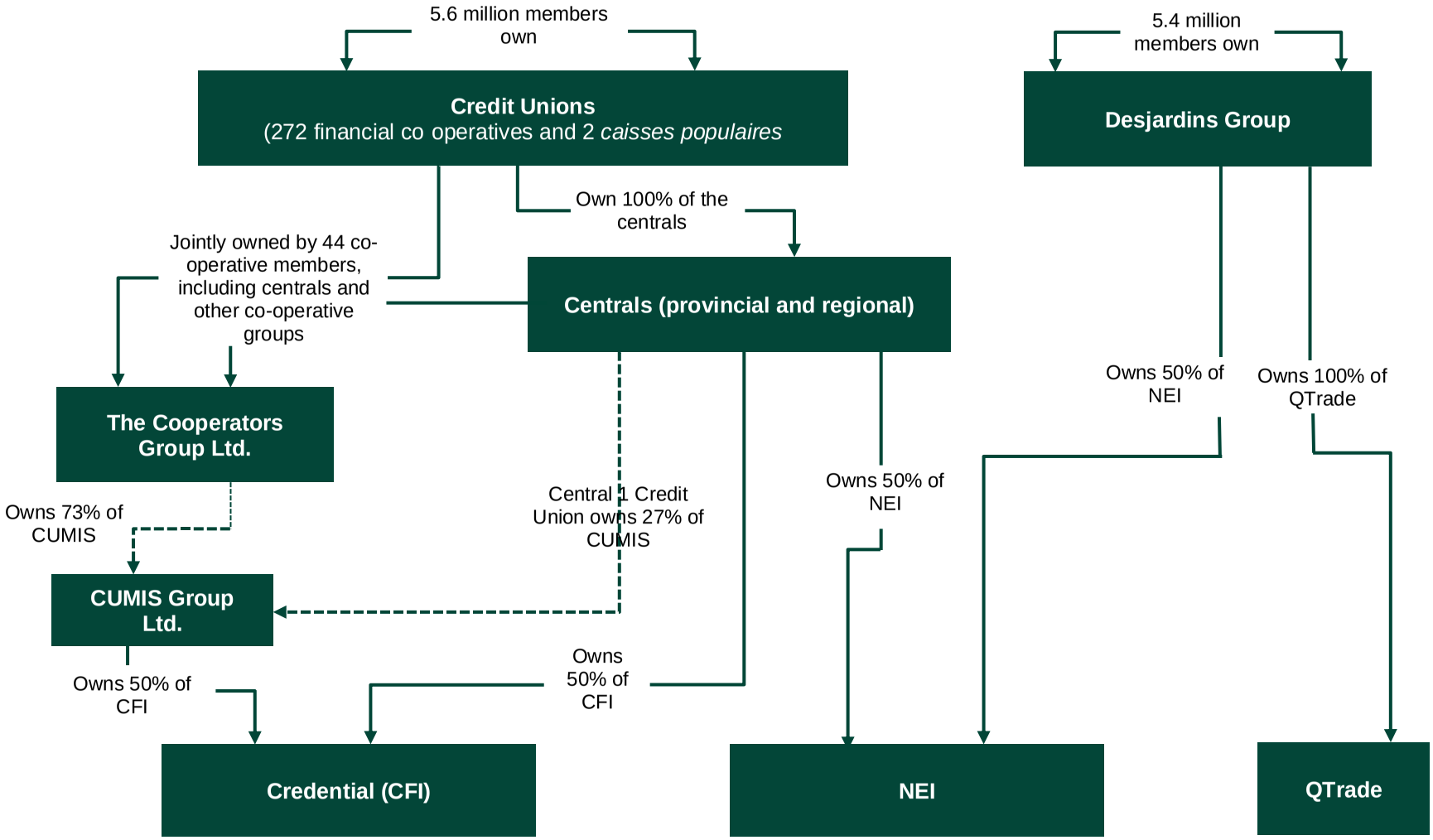
Source: Created by the case authors based on information from William O'Connell, "The Great Canadian Oligopoly: A Comparative Approach to Controlling the Shadow Banking Industry," *Journal of Public and International Affairs 2018*, Princeton University, 2018, https://jpia.princeton.edu/sites/g/files/toruqf1661/files/resource-links/jpia_2018.pdf, 80-93; and with data from IBISWorld, *Commercial Banking in Canada*, industry report 52211CA, September 2017.

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EXHIBIT 2: CANADIAN CREDIT UNIONS OWNERSHIP CHART (2015–16)



Note: NEI = Northwest & Ethical Investments L.P.; Qtrade = Credential Qtrade Securities Inc.; CUMIS = CUMIS General Insurance Company.
Source: Created by the case authors.